Suggestion from the author, hehe: play Sand Drawing by Judah Earl on repeat while reading. It’s a long read. Take your time. Anf if you wanna cry a little, do so. I did when writing this.

I have been thinking about love lately. About how much of it we spend our lives looking for it, how desperately we want to be loved, and how strangely we sometimes behave when someone finally tries to love us.

And I wonder whether some of us even know what we are looking for anymore.

I used to find genuine people strange.

There was something about people who were kind without needing anything from me, people who showed up because they wanted to, people who meant what they said and didn't make me question where I stood with them. I would almost find myself waiting for something to change. Surely there was a catch. Surely, at some point, the other shoe would drop.

It took me becoming more genuine myself to understand it.

Isn't that something? That sometimes, we don't recognise goodness because we haven't learnt to live in it. That we can become so accustomed to questioning people's intentions that an honest heart feels suspicious.

Sometimes, we spend so long expecting to be disappointed that, when someone gives us a reason not to be, we start looking for another reason to be.

And I think about the person I am becoming, the things I am learning, and the amount of love I seem to carry around in me.

Sometimes, I genuinely don't know what to do with all of it.

I want people to be okay. I want the people I love to know that they are loved. I want to be kind without calculating what I will get in return. I want to understand people, even when I don't understand their choices. I want to be able to acknowledge that someone hurt me without convincing myself that I must hate them for it.

I want to be able to say, "You hurt me," without having to say, "And now I hate you."

Not because I have never been hurt, or because I have mastered forgiveness. I am still human. Some things still hurt more than I know how to explain.

But I don't want the things that hurt me to become the things that define me. I don't want someone else's inability to love me well to become my inability to love anyone at all.

And perhaps that is why I think so much about people who don't know how to receive love.

What happens when someone finally offers you the very thing you have spent your life wishing for, and you don't know how to hold it?

What happens when someone is kind to you, and instead of feeling safe, you feel suspicious?

What happens when someone says they love you, and the first thing your heart asks is, "For how long?"

I wonder how many people are walking around like this. People who want to be held but stiffen when someone reaches for them. People who want to be understood but struggle to explain themselves. People who want someone to stay but have spent so much time preparing for abandonment that they don't know how to stop looking for the exit.

And I wonder how many of us became this way because, at some point, love stopped feeling safe.

Perhaps we should talk about rejection.

Not only the rejection that comes when a relationship ends, when someone chooses another person, or when the person you love tells you they no longer want to be with you.

I mean the rejection that happens when you are still a child and don't yet have the language to understand it. The kind that teaches you things about yourself before you are old enough to question whether those things are true.

Sometimes, your father leaves.

And you grow up.

You go to school. You make friends. You laugh at jokes. You celebrate birthdays. You become an adult who can hold conversations, make decisions, and get on with life.

Perhaps everyone assumes you are okay because you have learnt how to live without him.

But nobody asks what it was like to be a little boy or girl who needed their father and couldn't find him.

Nobody asks whether you ever wondered what was wrong with you. Whether you ever thought that perhaps, if you had been better, quieter, smarter, more obedient, more lovable, he might have stayed.

Nobody explains to you that you were a child. That you were never supposed to be impressive enough to convince a grown man to remain in your life.

You were supposed to be loved.

And there is something heartbreaking about the questions we carry from childhood into adulthood without realising we are still asking them.

Am I enough? Will you stay? What do I have to do to make you love me?

Perhaps the most painful question is this: if someone who was supposed to love me could leave, what makes me think anyone else will stay?

Sometimes, rejection doesn't look like someone leaving at all.

Sometimes, your parents stay, but you grow up feeling alone.

You are provided for, but nobody knows what to do when you cry. You are told that you are loved, but you don't quite know what that love is supposed to feel like. You learn how to be a good child, how not to cause trouble, how not to make life difficult for the people around you.

But nobody teaches you how to be a sad child.

Nobody teaches you that you can be frightened without being weak, angry without being bad, or lonely without being ungrateful.

So you learn to swallow things.

You swallow your tears because you don't want to be dramatic. You swallow your disappointment because you don't want to seem needy. You swallow your questions because you have learnt that some conversations make people uncomfortable.

Eventually, you become an adult who has mastered the art of saying, "I'm fine."

You say it when you are exhausted. You say it when you are lonely. You say it when you desperately need someone to ask you again, to look at you a little longer, to notice that the answer doesn't quite match the look on your face.

You say it because you don't know how to ask for what you need.

Or perhaps you do know, but you have convinced yourself that needing anything from anyone is dangerous.

And I think about men a lot when I think about this.

I think about the little boys who were told not to cry. The boys who fell and were told to get up before anyone even checked whether they were hurt. The boys who learnt that tenderness was embarrassing, that vulnerability was something to hide, and that the quickest way to escape the humiliation of feeling something was to pretend they felt nothing at all.

I think about the men who grew up believing their worth lay in what they could provide, how much they could endure, and how well they could protect everyone around them.

Men who learnt to be useful before they learnt how to be emotionally available.

Men who know how to work through pain but have no idea how to talk about it. Men who can tell you they are angry but cannot tell you that they are hurt. Men who can spend their entire lives being strong for other people and still have no idea how to let someone be strong for them.

Of course, women carry these wounds, too. We all do, in different ways. But I think there is something particularly heartbreaking about a boy growing into a man who has been taught that his feelings are a weakness he must overcome.

What happens when that man falls in love?

What happens when a woman looks at him and wants to know what is happening inside him, not because she wants to use it against him, but because she wants to know him?

What happens when she asks him how he feels, and he genuinely doesn't know how to answer?

What happens when he loves her but has never learnt how to communicate that love in a way she can feel?

Perhaps he withdraws. Perhaps he gets defensive. Perhaps he convinces himself that he doesn't care because caring gives another person the power to hurt him.

Perhaps he doesn't even recognize what he is doing.

I think about how lonely that must be. To want something you have never been taught how to hold. To need comfort and not know how to ask for it. To have someone looking at you with tenderness while you are still looking at yourself through the eyes of everyone who made you feel unworthy.

And I think about the women who love these men.

The women who keep asking, "What's wrong?" and receive silence. The women who explain their needs carefully because they don't want to sound demanding. The women who learn to recognize the smallest signs of affection because the bigger ones rarely come.

The women who begin to wonder whether they are asking for too much when all they want is to feel loved without having to guess.

The women who see the wounded child in a grown man and wish they could reach back through the years and give him the tenderness he missed.

Who want to tell him, "You don't have to do anything for me right now. You don't have to be strong. You don't have to have an answer. You can be sad. You can be frightened. I am not asking you to perform. I want you here."

And sometimes, he doesn't know what to do with that.

Sometimes, she doesn't know what to do with his silence either.

And two people who genuinely care about each other end up hurting each other in the space between what one person needs and what the other knows how to give.

That is what breaks my heart about this.

How many people have loved each other and still failed to make each other feel loved?

How many people have gone to bed beside someone they love and felt painfully alone?

How many people have mistaken their inability to receive love for proof that the love wasn't real?

And how many people have spent years trying to convince someone that their love is genuine, slowly becoming exhausted, wondering what else they could possibly do?

I wish I could tell those people that if they love someone hard enough, everything will eventually be okay.

I can't.

Because we have romanticized the idea of loving someone through their pain to the point that we sometimes forget the person doing the loving has a heart, too.

You can be patient with someone who is learning. You can reassure them, try to understand their fears, and give them room to discover that intimacy doesn't have to mean danger.

But you cannot go back and give them the childhood they deserved.

You cannot make their father return. You cannot make their mother hold them differently. You cannot erase every moment they felt unwanted or every experience that taught them to expect abandonment.

And you cannot keep breaking your own heart trying to prove that you are not the person who hurt them.

You can love someone with everything in you and still be unable to reach the part of them that believes they are unlovable.

That is a hard thing to accept when you are someone who wants so badly to help.

Sometimes, you see the goodness in someone. You see their tenderness when they forget to hide it. You see the person they might become if they could stop fighting every feeling that makes them vulnerable.

And you think, *If only they knew how loved they are. If only they could see themselves the way I see them.*

If only they understood that you aren't asking them to be perfect. You aren't asking them to have everything figured out. You are asking them to let you love them.

And perhaps that is where we must be careful.

Because loving someone means understanding them without deciding that you must save them. You can see someone's pain without making it your life's work to heal it. You can understand why they struggle to love you well and still admit that you are hurting.

You can love someone without making a home out of waiting for them to become ready.

I am learning that.

I am learning that having a lot of love in my heart doesn't mean everyone I meet will know what to do with it. It doesn't mean I can love someone into readiness, or make them understand my intentions simply by being sincere enough.

I can offer someone the gentlest version of myself, and they may still be frightened.

And that is a strange kind of grief.

To realize that something you are giving with an open heart can arrive in someone else's life as something they don't know how to trust.

To want to tell someone, "I am not here to hurt you," and understand that words cannot undo years of experience.

To wish you could reach into someone's chest, find the frightened part of them, and tell it that it can rest now.

That it doesn't have to earn every good thing.

That it doesn't have to be perfect to be chosen.

That someone leaving is not proof that it was never worth staying for.

That love is not an examination you must pass every day to keep your place in someone's life.

And perhaps, if I could say one thing to the people who struggle to receive love, it would be this.

I am sorry for the times you needed love and didn't receive it.

I am sorry for the times you cried and nobody noticed, or noticed and made you feel ashamed.

I am sorry for the times you had to become strong before you were ready, for the times you told yourself you didn't need anyone because needing someone hurt too much.

I am sorry if you grew up believing that being loved was something you had to earn by being good, useful, quiet, successful, or easy to deal with.

I am sorry if someone leaving taught you to question your worth.

You were a child.

You were allowed to need your parents.

You were allowed to want affection.

You were allowed to want someone to notice when you were hurting.

You were allowed to need more than survival.

And you deserved to be loved in ways you could feel.

You still do.

You deserve to have someone listen when you speak. You deserve kindness that doesn't disappear the moment you become inconvenient. You deserve relationships where you can make

mistakes, have difficult feelings, and tell the truth without fearing that every disagreement means you are about to be abandoned.

You deserve to experience love without having to spend every moment preparing for its end.

But you also deserve to learn how to let it in.

Not every person who comes close to you is going to hurt you. Not every kind gesture is a debt. Not every person who sees your vulnerability will use it against you.

You are allowed to take your time. You are allowed to have boundaries. You are allowed to be careful.

But I hope you don't spend the rest of your life punishing the people who love you for what someone else did.

I hope you learn to tell the difference between the past and the person standing in front of you.

I hope you learn that you can be frightened and still stay in the conversation. That you can be hurt and still explain what happened inside you. That you can apologize without believing you have made yourself unworthy of love.

That you can be a man and cry.

That you can admit you need someone without feeling ashamed.

And to the people who love someone who is still learning all of this, I hope you remember yourselves, too.

You are allowed to need tenderness. You are allowed to get tired. You are allowed to want a love you can feel, not one you must spend your days trying to uncover.

You do not have to become less loving to protect yourself. You have to remember that your love deserves care, too.

I think that is what I want most for us.

I want us to become people who can give love without using it to control, and receive love without treating it as a threat.

I want us to learn how to sit with our feelings instead of making everyone around us pay for the feelings we cannot name.

I want the boys who were told not to cry to grow into men who can say they are hurting without feeling ashamed.

I want the little girls who were made to feel difficult to love to grow into women who don't have to beg to be considered.

I want the children who were left to grow up knowing that someone's decision to leave was never a verdict on their worth.

And I want those of us who have learnt to love genuinely to keep that part of ourselves alive.

I want to keep being someone who can be kind without needing a reason. Someone who can forgive without pretending nothing happened. Someone who can recognise that people are complicated, that we all carry things we don't always know how to explain, and that sometimes the person hurting us is also a person who has been hurting for a very long time.

I want to keep having so much love in me that hate has very little room to settle.

But I am learning that I cannot save everyone I understand.

I cannot love everyone into becoming who they need to be.

And I cannot spend my life trying to prove that love is safe to someone who is unwilling to learn how to trust it.

I can only offer what is mine to offer, remain honest about what I need, and allow other people the dignity of doing their own work.

Perhaps learning to receive love begins with allowing ourselves to grieve the fact that we needed it so badly in the first place.

Maybe before we can hold someone else's love, we have to admit how much it hurt to go without it.

Maybe we have to mourn the father who never came back, the parent who never knew how to comfort us, the childhood in which we learnt to hide our tears, and the years we spent believing that being needed was the closest we would ever get to being loved.

Maybe we have to sit with that little version of ourselves and finally say the things nobody said.

You didn't ask for too much.

You weren't too sensitive.

You weren't difficult for needing comfort.

You didn't have to earn your place.

You deserved to be held.

And you deserved to know that you were loved, even on the days when you had nothing to offer.

I don't know how many people need to hear this. I don't know how many of us are quietly carrying these questions into our relationships, wondering why we cannot relax into something good, why we keep expecting the worst, why we feel so lonely even when someone tells us we are loved.

But I hope we begin to ask ourselves these questions gently.

I hope we stop confusing emotional survival with emotional health. I hope we stop celebrating our ability to endure everything while ignoring our need to be cared for.

And I hope that, one day, when someone looks at us with genuine affection, we don't immediately start preparing ourselves for the moment they change their mind.

I hope we let ourselves believe them.

Not blindly, not without discernment, but enough to experience what is happening while it is happening.

Enough to enjoy the kindness.

Enough to rest.

Enough to stop making love prove itself against every hurt we have ever known.

Because maybe some of us are not incapable of love.

Maybe we have simply never been shown what it looks like when love is allowed to be gentle.

Maybe we have been rejected so many times that acceptance feels suspicious. Maybe we have spent so long being the person who survives that we have forgotten we are also allowed to be the person who is cared for.

And maybe we can learn.

I want to believe that.

I want to believe that the person who once found genuine people strange can become someone who recognises and offers genuine love.

I want to believe that the man who never learnt how to talk about his feelings can one day sit across from someone he loves and tell her that he is afraid.

I want to believe that the person who was left can one day stop treating every goodbye as confirmation that they were never worth staying for.

I want to believe that we can become softer without becoming foolish, vulnerable without surrendering our dignity, and loving without losing ourselves.

Because I have so much love in me.

And I don't want to spend my life wondering whether it was too much, whether I should have given less, cared less, or become a little harder to protect myself from people who didn't know what to do with it.

I want to keep learning how to love.

I want to keep learning how to receive it.

And I want us to become people who can look at someone who is trying to love us and recognise the courage it takes to offer another human being a sincere heart.

Because it is a vulnerable thing, isn't it?

To say, "Here I am. This is what I have to give. I cannot promise to be perfect, but I will try to be honest with you. I will try to be kind. I will make room for your humanity. I will not ask you to earn the right to be treated with dignity."

It is a vulnerable thing to offer love without knowing whether it will be received.

And it is a vulnerable thing to receive it, too.

Perhaps that is why we must learn to do both.

Because there are people in this world who are desperately hoping to be loved, and people who are desperately trying to love them, and somewhere between the two, we are all trying to figure out how to be human.

I hope we figure it out.

I hope we learn to stay when staying is healthy, to speak when silence is hurting us, to apologise when we are wrong, and to leave when love has become a place where we keep losing ourselves.

I hope we learn that a person can be wounded without being broken beyond repair.

And I hope we learn that we can be wounded without having to spend the rest of our lives living as though the wound is all we are.

Because you are more than the person who left you.

You are more than the childhood you survived.

You are more than the affection you had to beg for.

You are more than the reasons someone gave you for not knowing how to love you.

And you are worthy of a love you do not have to spend your entire life trying to believe in.

Maybe that is where I want to leave this.

With the little boy who was told to stop crying.

With the little girl who learnt not to ask for too much.

With the grown man who doesn't know how to explain that he is hurting.

With the woman who keeps loving someone who cannot seem to let her close.

With all of us who have ever looked at something good and wondered how long we have before it disappears.

I hope you know that you were always worthy of tenderness.

Even then.

Even when they left.

Even when they didn't understand you.

Even when you learnt to hide the parts of yourself that needed love the most.

You were worthy of it before you learnt how to give it.

You were worthy of it before you became strong.

You were worthy of it before you became useful to anyone.

You were worthy of it before you learnt how to survive without it.

And you are worthy of it now.

I hope, one day, you let yourself believe that.

I hope, one day, you let yourself be loved.

And I hope that when love finally reaches you, you don't spend so long preparing for its departure that you forget to notice it has arrived.